In a sign of the way the winds were blowing, on 20 March Dost Mohammad's Minister, Mirza Sami Khan, invited Vitkevitch as his guest of honour to celebrate Nauroz, the Persian New Year. Burnes was pointedly not invited until the party had already begun and then refused to go; but he asked his Indian assistant, Mohan Lal Kashmiri, to go in his stead.

Mohan Lal had now been Burnes's invaluable munshi (or secretary) and adviser for seven years, since the two had first met in Delhi in 1831, when Mohan Lal was only twenty. His father had been a munshi on the Elphinstone mission twenty years earlier, and on his return had chosen to make Mohan Lal one of the first boys in north India to be educated according to the English curriculum in the new Delhi College. Clever, ambitious and fluent in English, Urdu, Kashmiri and Persian, Mohan Lal had accompanied Burnes on his trip to Bukhara, after which he worked for some time as an 'intelligencer' for Wade in Kandahar, corresponding frequently with Masson, his counterpart in Kabul. Burnes relied on and trusted Mohan Lal completely, not least as he had shown himself willing to pay the ultimate price for his loyalty and friendship to Burnes: in December 1834 his own Kashmiri Pundit community had formally outcaste him as a result of his open expressions of religious scepticism and frequent caste violations. He was now forbidden 'to drink out of the same cup with them . . . They discarded me from their society . . . so I am now left without friends and without a place to reside in my native city of Delhi.'[100]

Mohan Lal later wrote in English a remarkable book of his travels and a scholarly two-volume biography of Dost Mohammad. In the latter he gives his own account of his meeting with Vitkevitch at Mirza Sami Khan's Nauroz party. On arrival he found that the Minister and Vitkevitch:

> sat a little higher than the others, on the 'nihali' [dais], and the former, to show his civility . . . placed me by the side of the Russian envoy. While the music was going on, the minister was conversing on politics, sometimes with M Vitkevitch and sometimes with me, inquiring about the number of English troops stationed at Ludhiana, the distance between the divisions at Kurnal, Meerut and Kanpur; and whether the Mahomedans were the major part of the army or the Rajputs; and what were the feelings of the natives of India towards the decayed household of the great Timur [the Mughals]. Understanding the manner in which the inquiries were made, I came to the conclusion that every question was put to me according to arrangements made previous to my joining the party . . .

The conversation then moved on to the flourishing trade between Russia and Kashmir, which Vitkevitch said he hoped to help the Afghans reclaim